of these, which never materialized, even set out to target the Simon Commission in Delhi, so daring and determined was the HSRA.

The murder created an instant stir. It won the admiration of members of the Congress Party. Although the latter had previously disapproved of the tactics of the HSRA revolutionaries, they now began to provide them with financial assistance.[10] Ajoy Ghosh, who had stood trial with Bhagat Singh in the Lahore Conspiracy Case but had been acquitted, said of the murder, 'well-timed and daringly executed, it was an action that was acclaimed by the public with joy'.[11] And yet, it seems that Bhagat Singh himself remained not altogether untroubled by the deed. Shiv Verma, another accomplice of his, claimed that 'Bhagat Singh remained upset for some days',[12] given the bloodshed. Nevertheless, what was ultimately acknowledged even at the highest levels was, as Jawaharlal Nehru put it, that 'Bhagat Singh did not become popular because of his act of terrorism, but because he seemed to vindicate, for the moment, the honour of Lala Lajpat Rai; and through him the nation'. So much so that, 'within a few months, each town and village of the Punjab . . . resounded with Bhagat Singh's name' and very soon 'innumerable songs grew up about him'.[13]

For a man who met with such a high-profile death at the gallows, the bitterest irony for those who revered him is that both he and his comrades were initially destined to get clean away with this gruesome murder. The murder had taken place in broad daylight at 4.30 p.m. It was executed in the immediate vicinity of the police station on College Road. Rajguru had fired the first shot. But no attempt was then made for the assailants to get away. Instead, Bhagat Singh had moved in to fire a further seven shots himself afterwards. The killers had then fled in the opposite direction through the gates of the DAV College. As they fled, there had been one other unnecessary fatality. Chandrashekhar Azad had shot at Constable Chanan Singh as he gave chase, killing him instantly. And yet, the authorities did not have the slightest clue about the assailants or where even to begin with their inquiries. On 10 January 1929, a telegram from the viceroy in India to the secretary of state for India recorded how the 'first phase of investigation has ended in the release on bail of all the persons arrested'. They were not